Going Places

Indian films travelling the international festival circuit



TWO SISTERS AND A HUSBAND

Premiering at this year's Tribeca Film Festival (June 8-19), Shlok Sharma's *Two Sisters and a Husband* makes suspenseful a love triangle: Amrita (Manya Grover) is in love with Rajat (Dinker Sharma), but when he marries her sister Tara (Avani Rai), what will she now do with his child she is pregnant with?



SHOEBOX

A highlight of the ongoing New York Indian Film Festival, Faraz Ali's *Shoebox* shows how a daughter fights to save her father's single-screen theatre in Allahabad. Set during the time of the city's renaming as Prayagraj, the film makes all change—personal, political—seem charged like dynamite.



JAGGI

Having premiered at the Indian Film Festival of Los Angeles, Anmol Sidhu's *Jaggi* returned with two awards earlier this month—Best Feature Film Debut and the Audience Choice Award for Best Feature. The film upturns our notions of Punjabi masculinity by telling the story of a male sexual assault victim.

FILM

TRAUMA'S ETERNAL RETURN



A new film shows that, for Kashmiris, home is where the hurt is

In one of the more affecting scenes in *I'm Not the River Jhelum*'s, we see a couple of Kashmiri locals watch home minister Amit Shah read the statutory resolution which revoked Jammu & Kashmir's special status. As the Opposition's heckles drown out Shah's voice, the two Kashmiris look on with a palpable dread. Kashmir changes quickly, and yet, seemingly, never does. It is for capturing this and so many other ironies that Prabhash Chandra won a Best Debut India Director award at this year's International Film Festival of Kerala (IFFK).

Speaking to INDIA TODAY a few days after *River Jhelum* was screened at the Kolkata International Film Festival on April 29, Chandra tells us how he fell in love with theatre despite having a Master's degree in Nuclear Physics. "My inclination was towards writing and directing because I found I was a very bad actor."

PRABHASH CHANDRA won a Best Debut India Director award at this year's IFFK

In 2014, the Delhi-based Chandra visited Pulwama for the first time as a theatre workshop facilitator. When he saw that the local children were refusing to open up to him, Chandra thought it best to listen and not tell. "When I started to listen to them, I found most of them were traumatised, one way or another. The torture that the students had to endure during periods when Section 144 is imposed for 4-5 months was something I learned about first-hand. I also heard stories from their parents," says Chandra.



Affected by the varying kinds of trauma he had witnessed, Chandra decided to channel his own feelings into a feature film in 2018: "My brief was that we should try to recreate the uncertainty and the suffocation."

There's a glorious transition in the film, where a character bites into a biscuit and we cut to an explosion. "One evening in 2015, I was feeling suffocated and my eyes had started to burn. There was a local with me who seemed fine, and he told me without the slightest hint of panic in his voice—'There's an encounter going on nearby, they've released tear gas'. I was really scared at that moment, and the person was reacting as if it was the most normal thing ever." When asked about Vivek Agnihotri's *The Kashmir Files*, Chandra didn't play coy: "Many have irrationally lapped it up as the truth. Such films are like slow poison."

Even though he realises his own film, too, might prove controversial, Chandra is undeterred. "I feel scared, but what scares me more is if I cower now, the next wave of fear will engulf everyone. I carry these two lines: "*Kya zulmaton ke daur main bhi geet gaye jayenge? Haan, zulmaton ke daur ke hi geet gaye jayenge.* (Will there be songs during times of tyranny? Yes, only songs born out of tyranny will be sung!)" ■

–Tatsam Mukherjee